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A

A. The green growth transition (“greening”) has been called a modern-day industrial revolution due to its expected large structural impact on labour markets worldwide (Bowen et al., 2016). According to the United Nations Environment Programme (2008), a “green economy” is one that results in improved human well-being and social equity, while significantly reducing environmental risks. Policy-makers have two main goals for the green economy: managing the transition to green jobs and promoting green economic growth (Martinez-Fernandez et al., 2010). The impact on employment is one important way for policy-makers to assess the effects of environmental policies pursuing these goals. However, the definition of a “green job” is not universal.

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B

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B

B. For instance, a secretary could be called a green worker in a renewable energy company but not in a fossil fuel company, even if the work is the same. Since the definition of green jobs influences policy decisions, standardised criteria to classify jobs as “green” need to be adopted. This involves recognizing what makes green jobs different from other jobs. Are there skills specific to green jobs, or does the label “green” merely reflect the type of job to which the same skills are applied? The similarity of skills used in green and non-green jobs can also help determine the content of re-training programmes. If the skill sets required for green jobs are largely different from their non-green counterparts, then non-green workers may need extensive off-the-job training to supplement on-the-job training, in order to enable the transition to the green economy.

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C

C. Although the literature on green jobs is expanding, the research on skill needs for green growth is still patchy. Fankhauser et al. (2008) note that there is relatively little information on the productivity, pay and other attributes of jobs created and destroyed by climate-change policies. Cedefop (2010) complains that “We have not paid enough attention to the social dimension of sustainable development: its implications for employment, training and skills.” Even in countries with relatively good labour market data, it is difficult to identify which job skills are most likely to be affected by green growth policies. For example, Hatfield-Dodds et al. (2008) note that in Australia “current information on green skills and workforce capabilities is very poor.”

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D

D. Recently, studies have used the O*NET database to learn more about green jobs. This database, created by the US Department of Labor, includes detailed information on job tasks and skills, and identifies specific green tasks. Researchers Vona et al. (2017) are using O*NET's task information to construct a measure of “greenness” and identify general categories of green skills. They have found that green occupations are less routine-intensive and higher-skill than non-green occupations and require high-level analytical and technical skills related to technology. Similarly, it has been pointed out that that green jobs involve more high-level abstract skills, and require more education, work experience, and on-the-job training (Consoli et al., 2015).

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E

E. These researchers are also constructing a measure of “skill distance,” which indicates the extent of re-training required to transition from one job to another (Vona et al., 2017). For example, the skill distance (and hence required re-training) would be smaller between a marketing manager and a sales manager than between a marketing manager and a software developer. Vona et al. (2017) have found considerable variation both within and among major occupational groups. As they outline, there is some evidence that engineers, scientists, and operation managers have the smallest skill distance across jobs, whereas the largest skill differences are concentrated in a few low- and medium-skill occupations.

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F

F. Our findings support this research and provide additional insights for policymakers on green jobs and how to transition to them. Using O*NET's broad definition of green jobs, 19.4% of the US workforce could currently be considered to be part of the green economy, although a large proportion of green employment would be “indirectly” green. Additionally, green jobs vary in “greenness” (the use and importance of green tasks), with very few jobs consisting solely of green tasks. This variability suggests that the term “green” should be considered as a continuum rather than a binary characteristic. Furthermore, greening is likely to involve transitions on a scale and scope similar to existing job transitions. While it is easier to transition to indirectly green rather than directly green jobs, non-green jobs generally appear to differ from their green counterparts in only a few skill-specific aspects, indicating that most re-training can occur on-the-job. Consequently, the green economy has significant potential for short-run growth, provided that job transitions are strategically managed.

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